Modi didn’t handle his own Twitter and Facebook page. That was done by a team of hired professionals based out of Ahmedabad, Gandhinagar and other smaller centres. Leading them was Hiren Joshi, a computer science lecturer in a college in Bhilwara, Rajasthan, who had been assigned as OSD to Modi. It was this team that ensured a constant engagement on Twitter. Joshi first met Modi when he attended a function for computer engineers which had been organized by the Gujarat government in 2009. Apparently, a technical glitch developed at the meeting which Joshi solved instantaneously. Modi was impressed enough to recruit Joshi to lead his social media outreach—one more evidence of his talent-spotting skills. It was Joshi who would provide Modi a daily late-night update on his Twitter messages, supervise all Twitter interactions, and help translate Modi’s Twitter account into half a dozen regional languages.

‘We had a clear goal—don’t allow the buzz around Modiji to drop through the election, keep our leader and what he says and does trending all the time,’ says a Modi social media team member.

Statistically, it was as one-sided as it could get. According to Twitter India, during the elections a total of 56 million election-related tweets were sent out. Modi was mentioned in 11.1 million tweets, almost 20 per cent of the total traffic. Arvind Kejriwal was next with 5 million (9 per cent) and Rahul Gandhi well behind with just 1.2 million tweets (or 2 per cent).

Kejriwal was at least giving Modi a fight on the social media meter. A small team working out of the party headquarters in Delhi and wired to NRI supporters would work tirelessly to take on the BJP media machine or raise funds for the party through crowdsourcing. ‘We found social media a relatively cheap and effective way to take our message forward,’ is how Kejriwal put it to me.

That a party which was just a year old was scoring better than the Congress on the social media meter reflects just how ill prepared Rahul’s team was. In the ‘pappu’ (Rahul) versus ‘feku’ (Modi) hashtag war, there was again only one clear leader. Every time, Rahul spoke, BJP supporters would swarm all over the social media and start trending ‘pappu’ to ridicule